

Museum of the Recent Past

Hall 7 — *The Age of Anxious Comfort* (c. 2010–2035)

Selected Curator's Notes

The following placards accompany the everyday artefacts recovered from Habitation Site 14-B, formerly known as “a studio apartment in Brooklyn.” Visitors are reminded that the people of this era, despite owning more objects than any humans in history, described themselves at the time as “struggling.”

Exhibit 1 — Rectangular Devotional Object

c. 2007–2031 · glass, cobalt, lithium · approx. 174 g

Known colloquially as a “phone,” though by this period the device had largely ceased to be used for speaking. The Modern Person carried it at all times, sleeping with it closer than their spouse. Anthropological debate continues as to whether the object was a tool, a companion, or a parasite; consensus now leans toward the third. Battery depletion below 7% triggered a ritual response known as “asking a stranger for a charger,” an act of vulnerability otherwise unparalleled in the era.

Exhibit 2 — Rolled Cushion of Good Intentions

c. 2008–2028 · polyvinyl chloride, unfulfilled resolutions

Found in the corner of every habitation, often still shrink-wrapped. The Modern Person purchased these in bursts of optimism — typically the first week of January — and used them chiefly as a surface upon which to lie and scroll (see Exhibit 1). The cushion was believed to confer spiritual benefit merely by being owned, much as earlier peoples believed in relics. Curators note the contradiction: an object for the body, employed almost exclusively to avoid using the body.

Exhibit 3 — Vessel of Moral Superiority

c. 2015–2034 · stainless steel, misplaced virtue

The Modern Person was deeply concerned with the planet and expressed this concern by purchasing a forty-dollar metal container, then forgetting it at home and buying plastic water at the gym. The bottle's primary function was visible: to be carried into meetings and placed ostentatiously on the desk, signalling to colleagues that the owner was “hydrated” and, by extension, virtuous. A single household often contained nine such vessels, none of which were ever washed.

Exhibit 4 — Collective Suffering Chamber (reconstructed)

c. 2010–2026 · exposed brick, noise-cancelling headphones, ambient despair

A workspace in which thirty to ninety individuals were seated within earshot of one another and instructed to “collaborate.” Collaboration, in practice, meant overhearing a colleague’s divorce being negotiated by phone while pretending not to. Each worker responded by donning large padded headphones — an explicit admission that the design had failed — and communicating only via the rectangular devotional object (see Exhibit 1). The chamber was abolished in 2026 following the Great Webcam Strike, after which workers simply refused to put on trousers.

Exhibit 5 — Catalogue of Romantic Rejections

c. 2012–2033 · software, hope, fatigue

An application that presented photographs of nearby strangers and required the user to approve or dismiss them with a flick of the thumb — a gesture formerly reserved for shooing flies. The Modern Person would, over an average lifetime, dismiss approximately eleven thousand humans, exchange messages with forty-three, meet twelve, and date three. They would then complain that they could not find “anyone.” Scholars are divided on whether the application caused the loneliness epidemic of the period or merely monetised it.

Exhibit 6 — Botanical Surrogate Child

c. 2014–2032 · monstera deliciosa, guilt

The Modern Person, having declined or postponed actual parenthood, directed parental feeling toward leafy vegetation. Plants were given names (“Gregory,” “Brenda”), spoken to, photographed, and posted to strangers as evidence of the owner’s capacity to nurture. Mortality rates among these plants exceeded 70% within the first six months of adoption — a figure the Modern Person attributed to “bad light” rather than to their own absence, which was, on average, eleven hours per day at the office (see Exhibit 4).

Exhibit 7 — Bound Volume of Advice, Unread

c. 1990–2028 · paper, good intentions, page 27

The Modern Person accumulated these in great numbers, displaying them prominently on shelves as a kind of armour against the suspicion that they were not, in fact, “doing the work.” Titles promised to fix everything: anxiety, money, relationships, the inability to get out of bed. Internal examination of surviving copies reveals a consistent pattern: heavy annotation through chapter two, then pristine pages thereafter. The book’s true purpose, it is now agreed, was the act of buying it.

Exhibit 8 — Green Fruit, Status Object

c. 2010–2029 · persea americana, mortgage implications

A soft green fruit that, for reasons scholars still find baffling, became the single most contested object of the era. Economists of the period seriously argued that young adults could not afford houses because they were spending four dollars on the fruit, mashed, on toast. The Modern Person, in turn, defended the toast with a fervour ordinarily reserved for religious doctrine. Both sides agreed, implicitly, that the house was the more important object, and that the fruit was the more attainable. This, more than anything, summarises the age.

Exit through the gift shop, where replica rectangular devotional objects (non-functional) are available for purchase at forty-two credits.